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PEOPLE

Seema Purushothaman



PROGRAMMES

MA in Development

LOCATION

Bengaluru

SCHOOL

School of Development

CONTACT

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smallfarmdynamics.wordpress.com

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Areas of Interest & Expertise

- Ecological Economics
- Agrarian Studies
- Sustainability

Biography

Seema's career spans over three decades. Her work is located at the interface of societies, development, and ecosystems. It evolved from that of a field officer to field research, to conceptual explorations, and then towards action research and advocacy.

Geographically, her engagements span across peri urban zones, production landscapes and forest peripheries. By now, Seema has spent 12 years at the University, integrating concepts and realities in teaching, inclusive action research and in advocacy.

A bachelor's degree (1982-86) from Kerala Agricultural University provided her with a multi-disciplinary base that kindled a strong aptitude towards Economics, especially Indian economy. Leaving a position with the Government of Kerala, she then pursued a Master's degree in Agricultural Economics writing her dissertation on the economic impact of industrial pollution on farmers. This published work trained Seema's interest towards environmental Economics, then a newly emerging field.

While working at the Institute of Economic Growth as a Research Assistant, Seema secured a Ford Foundation scholarship to join the Environmental Economics programme at University College London. That was the

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beginning of a long journey with the concept and practice of sustainability.

Her journey as an environmental economist became visible in 1991, through a global scale economic valuation of tropical forests. This was followed by a decade long involvement in projects around water and forest related issues in various parts of India. She has been applying Environmental Economics also to study *adivasi* communities of southern India, culminating in her doctoral thesis on the economics of tribal land use. This was the beginning of her engagements with the rights and livelihoods of indigenous communities.

Her field experience and engagement with the discourse on sustainable development and her association with networks like SANDEE (South Asian Network for Development and Environmental Economics), INSEE (Indian Society for Ecological Economics) and various



to Combat Desertification (UNCCD) has been constantly infusing social-institutional, distributional, educational and political dimensions of sustainability in her work.

Nine years spent at ATREE (Ashoka Trust for Ecology and the Environment) from 2003, just before joining the University, helped her sharpen this interdisciplinary lens. This lens influenced her teaching and was instrumental in consolidating her attention towards Ecological Economics.

Seema's teaching has been anchored in interdisciplinary programmes at both PhD and postgraduate levels. Long encounter with field realities in India and other parts of

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the Global South, together with the insights gleaned from the diverse and interactive community at the University, catalysed the emergence of an action researcher cum real time educator.

Work

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Books

വനാവകാശ നിയമപ്രകാരമുള്ള
സാമൂഹികഅവകാശങ്ങൾ: ഗോത്ര
വിഭാഗങ്ങളിലെ
യുവജനങ്ങൾക്കായുള്ള പരിശീലനം

Seema Purushothaman (2024)

University Working Paper Series

Towards a New Development Equilibrium
among the Forest Dependent Adivasis of
Central India - A Case for Agrarian Adaptive
Skilling

Seema Purushothaman (2022)

Courses taught in collaboration with other institutions:

Trigger change! Innovative agriculture solutions for
land restoration

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Publications

Book

- Purushothaman, S., & Patil, S. (2019). *Agrarian change and Urbanization in Southern India*. Springer Nature, Singapore. https://azimpremjiuniversity.edu.in/SitePages/pdf/Purushothaman_Patil_2019_City_the_Peasant.pdf

Edited Book

- Purushothaman, S., & Abraham, R. (Ed.). (2013). *Livelihood Strategies in Southern India — Conservation and Poverty Reduction in Forest Fringes*. Springer, New Delhi, India. ([Flyer](#))

Video

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Journal Articles

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- Purushothaman, Sadashiva and Dhanush. 2022. Agroecological Impacts of Urban Demand for Fresh Vegetables: Preliminary Insights from Exploratory

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- Dhanya, B., Satish, B.N., Viswanath, S., & Purushothaman, S. (2014). Ecosystem services of native trees: experience from two traditional agroforestry systems in Karnataka, Southern India. *International Journal of Biodiversity Science, Ecosystem Services and Management*, 10(2), 101 – 111.
- Purushothaman, S., Patil, S., Francis, I., Patil, I., & Nesheim, I. (2013). Policy and Governance for sustaining livelihoods and natural resources in small farms — a case study in Karnataka. *Indian Journal of Agricultural Economics*, 68 (2), 240 – 257. (PDF)

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Working Papers and Policy Briefs

- Seema Purushothaman, Sheetal Patil, Parijat Ghosh, Dibyendu Chaudhuri, Amit Kumar Singh, Bibhubanta Barad, Saurabh Singh, Jostine A and Mahendra Kumar Singh (2022). *Towards a New Development Equilibrium among the Forest Dependent Adivasis of Central India — A Case for Agrarian Adaptive Skilling* (APU Working Paper No.25)<https://azimpremjiuniversity.edu.in/publications/2022/working-paper-series/towards-a-new-development-equilibrium-among-the-forest-dependent-a-divasis-of-central-india-a-case-for-agrarian-adaptive-skilling>
- Purushothaman and Vanjari.2022. *One Part Farmers: Villages two decades after land acquisition for the Bengaluru International Airport*. Working Paper 23. Azim Premji University. Bangalore. <https://azimpremjiuniversity.edu.in/publications/2022/working-paper-series/one-part-farmers-villages-two-decades-after-land-acquisition-for-the-bengaluru-international-airport>

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- Purushothaman, S., Patil, S., Raghvendra, S., Vanjari, R.S., & Shwetha, A. R. (2021). *Urban Wastewater for Agriculture: Farmers' Perspectives from Peri-urban Bengaluru (Working Paper No. 20)*, Azim Premji University.
- Purushothaman, S, Patil, S., & Lodha, S. (2016). *Social and Environmental Transformation in the Indian Peri-Urban Interface — Emerging Questions*. (Working Paper No. 1). Azim Premji University. ([PDF](#))
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Handbook

- വനാവകാശ നിയമപ്രകാരമുള്ള സാമൂഹികഅവകാശങ്ങൾ: ഗോത്ര വിഭാഗങ്ങളിലെ യുവജനങ്ങൾക്കായുള്ള പരിശീലനം

Current Projects:

1. Adaptive Skilling through Action Research in the tribal villages of Central India <https://www.pradan.net/samparak/adaptive-skilling-through-action-research-asar/>
2. Forest Rights Act – facilitating the implementation of the Act as a knowledge partner in Kerala and Rajasthan
3. Impact of urban consumption on periurban ecology and farmers around Bengaluru (2021 to 2024) – a study funded by the Ministry of Science & Technology of Govt. of India as part of Indo-German scientific collaboration

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